



# The TCM Food Color Guide

*How to Balance Your Plate Using the Yeh Color  
System*



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TCM NATURAL HEALTH

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## About the Author

**Dr. Timothy Yeh** was the President of the Yeh Center of Natural Medicine in Upland, California. Over the course of five decades, he treated more than 500,000 patients using a comprehensive system that combined twelve types of natural medicine -- including acupuncture, herbal medicine, nutrition therapy, and bodywork.

Dr. Yeh developed the **Five Step Model of Systematic Natural Medicine** and his proprietary diagnostic method known as **Causenosis™**, which aimed to identify and address the root causes of illness rather than merely treating symptoms.

He held a Ph.D. in Acupuncture, an O.M.D. (California), an O.M.D. (China), an M.D. (China), a D.Sc. (Honorary), and was a Licensed Acupuncturist in the state of California.

Dr. Yeh passed away after a lifetime dedicated to healing, leaving behind a rich legacy of clinical wisdom. His book *Seasonal Balanced Food Medicine* captures one of his most practical teachings: the Food Color Balance system that is the foundation of this guide.

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*"The color of food is not decoration -- it is information. Your body reads color the way a musician reads notes."*

-- Dr. Timothy Yeh

# What Is the TCM Color Balance?

In Traditional Chinese Medicine, the color of food is far more than a visual trait. Each color communicates with specific organ systems in the body, influencing energy flow, temperature, and function. This is not a metaphor -- it reflects thousands of years of clinical observation refined by generations of practitioners.

Dr. Timothy Yeh took this ancient understanding and developed something remarkably practical: a **numerical color-value system** that assigns every food a score ranging from **+12 (most yang)** to **-12 (most yin)**. Yang foods are warming and activating. Yin foods are cooling and nourishing. The goal is simple: eat a balanced spectrum of colors each day so that your plate's total color score lands as close to **zero** as possible.

## The Green Fulcrum

Green sits at the center of the scale with a value of **0**. It is the fulcrum that balances yin and yang. This is precisely why TCM practitioners have always emphasized green vegetables -- they harmonize the body without pushing it toward excess heat or excess cold.

When in doubt, add more green to your plate.

## Why Color Matters

Think of your body as an orchestra. Each organ system needs specific nutrients, and those nutrients are carried by the pigments that give food its color. Red foods carry compounds that support blood and circulation. Orange and yellow foods nourish digestion and immunity. Purple and dark foods support the kidneys and bones.

When you eat a colorful, balanced plate, you're providing your body with a full symphony of nutrients. When you eat a monotone plate -- all beige, all red, or all white -- some organ systems get too much stimulation while others are neglected.

## The Simplicity of the System

Dr. Yeh designed this system to be used at every meal, by anyone. You don't need to memorize Chinese medical theory. You don't need to calculate anything precisely. You

simply need to:

1. **Look at your plate** -- are there at least five different colors?
2. **Check the balance** -- do your warm-colored foods (reds, oranges, yellows) roughly match your cool-colored foods (blues, purples, whites, blacks)?
3. **Add green** -- always include green vegetables as your anchor.

The chapters that follow will give you the full scoring system, food lists, and practical meal plans. But the core principle is this: **color balance is health balance**.

# The Color Spectrum

## *Yang to Yin*

Below is Dr. Yeh's complete Food Color Value System. Yang (warming) foods sit at the top with positive values. Yin (cooling) foods sit at the bottom with negative values. Green, at zero, is the balance point.

| YANG -- WARMING & ACTIVATING |                  |                                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| +12                          | Charcoal / Burnt | Charcoal-grilled rice, heavily charred or burnt foods                                                                                            |
| +10                          | Dry Black        | Coffee, black pepper, dark toast, dark roasted tea                                                                                               |
| +9                           | Dark Red         | Red apple peel, red onion, adzuki bean, cranberry, pomegranate                                                                                   |
| +8                           | Red              | Tomato, red meat, red bell pepper, strawberry, red sausage                                                                                       |
| +7                           | Light Red        | Red radish peel, watermelon flesh, goji berry, raspberry                                                                                         |
| +6                           | Dark Orange      | Pumpkin, sweet potato, millet, papaya, turmeric                                                                                                  |
| +5                           | Orange           | Carrot, tangerine, orange peel, apricot, peach                                                                                                   |
| +4                           | Light Orange     | Orange juice, mandarin juice, cantaloupe, mango                                                                                                  |
| +3                           | Dark Yellow      | Chrysanthemum tea, day lily, golden beet, saffron                                                                                                |
| +2                           | Yellow           | Lemon, egg yolk, corn, butter, banana, yellow squash                                                                                             |
| +1                           | Light Yellow     | Napa cabbage, sesame seed, pineapple, chickpea, ginger                                                                                           |
| NEUTRAL -- THE BALANCE POINT |                  |                                                                                                                                                  |
| 0                            | Green            | <b>All green</b> broccoli, spinach, kale, celery, cucumber, green beans, <b>vegetables:</b> green apple, avocado, zucchini, peas, lettuce, herbs |
| YIN -- COOLING & NOURISHING  |                  |                                                                                                                                                  |

|     |                     |                                                                                            |
|-----|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| -1  | Light Blue          | Filtered water, chlorella, spirulina                                                       |
| -2  | Blue                | Blueberry, blue corn                                                                       |
| -3  | Dark Blue           | Liver (as food), dark blue plum                                                            |
| -7  | Light Purple        | Violet, lavender, light purple potato                                                      |
| -8  | Purple              | Blackberry, eggplant, nori (seaweed), purple chili                                         |
| -9  | Dark Purple         | Purple grape, purple cabbage, purple fig, acai berry                                       |
| -10 | Light Grey / White  | Tofu, soy sauce, white mushroom, cauliflower, white onion                                  |
| -11 | Moist Black / White | Daikon, coconut, black sesame, goat milk, soy milk, cow milk, egg white, wood ear mushroom |
| -12 | Dark Moist Black    | Black bean, black rice, black mushroom, dark seaweed                                       |

### How to Read This Chart

Positive numbers (+) indicate **yang** -- warming, activating energy. Negative numbers (-) indicate **yin** -- cooling, nourishing energy. A balanced meal aims for a total near **zero**. You don't need exact math -- just make sure your warm colors and cool colors are roughly in proportion.

## Color-to-Organ Map

Each color group nourishes specific organ systems. When you understand these connections, you can tailor your meals to support the areas of your body that need the most attention.

| Color Group         | Organ Systems                        | Body Systems Supported                           |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| ● Red               | Heart, small intestine               | Blood, circulatory system, mental focus          |
| ● Orange & Yellow   | Stomach, spleen                      | Digestive system, immune system, muscular system |
| ● Green             | All organs, particularly gallbladder | All systems -- the universal balancer            |
| ● Dark Green & Blue | Gallbladder, liver                   | Hormonal, metabolic, nervous system              |
| ● Indigo & Purple   | Kidney, urinary bladder              | Bone system, reproductive system                 |
| ● White             | Lung, large intestine                | Digestive, immune, nervous, lymphatic systems    |
| ● Moist Black (yin) | Kidney, urinary bladder              | Bone, reproductive system                        |
| ● Dry Black (yang)  | Whole body                           | Essence, body fluids, water metabolism           |

## Practical Health Tips from Dr. Yeh

Dr. Yeh often shared targeted food-color recommendations with his patients. Here are some of the most common ones:



### ● Heart & Circulatory Support

Eat more **adzuki (red) beans** and **red-peel apples**. However, Dr. Yeh cautioned against excess red meat for those with heart concerns -- plant-based reds are gentler on the cardiovascular system.

### ● Digestive & Blood Sugar Support

For **stomach issues**, avoid excess butter, brown sugar, and sweets. Instead, reach for **brown rice** and yellow-hued vegetables. For **blood sugar management**, orange and yellow foods are especially helpful: **pumpkin, butternut squash, lemon, corn, and millet**.

### ● Weight Management & Gallbladder Health

Want to **lose weight** or **prevent gallstones**? Green is your best friend. Dr. Yeh recommended eating plenty of green vegetables with every meal -- they clear, detoxify, and balance without adding excess heat or cold.

### ● Immune & Respiratory Support

For **chronic fatigue, fibromyalgia, or sinusitis**, Dr. Yeh recommended more white-colored foods: **white onion, daikon radish, white mushrooms**, and similar light-colored vegetables that support the lung and immune systems.

## How to Score Your Plate

Scoring your plate is straightforward. Look at each food on your plate, find its color value from the chart in Chapter 2, and add them up. A balanced meal will total somewhere between **-5 and +5**. A perfectly balanced meal totals **zero**.

You don't need precision -- estimating is perfectly fine. The purpose is awareness, not arithmetic.

### Example 1: Typical American Breakfast

#### Ham, Eggs & Coffee

|                         |     |
|-------------------------|-----|
| ● Ham & sausage (red)   | +8  |
| ● Eggs (yellow)         | +2  |
| ● Orange juice (orange) | +5  |
| ● Coffee (dry black)    | +10 |

**Total: +25 -- Heavily yang! Too much heat.**

This breakfast is overwhelmingly warm and activating. There are no cooling, nourishing foods to bring it into balance. Over time, eating this way daily can contribute to excess heat in the body -- inflammation, restlessness, digestive discomfort.

### Example 2: Dr. Yeh's Balanced Vegetable & Bean Soup

## Rainbow Vegetable & Bean Soup

|                                           |     |
|-------------------------------------------|-----|
| ● Cauliflower, celery (green)             | 0   |
| ● Miso, soy sauce (dark)                  | +10 |
| ● Filtered water (blue)                   | -1  |
| ● Beets, red beans (dark red)             | +9  |
| ● Corn (yellow)                           | +2  |
| ● Carrots, sweet potato (orange)          | +6  |
| ● Tofu (white/grey)                       | -10 |
| ● Purple cabbage (purple)                 | -7  |
| ● Black beans, black rice, black mushroom | -10 |

**Total: -1 -- Nearly perfectly balanced!**

Notice how Dr. Yeh built this soup with every color group represented. The yang warmth from miso and red beans is offset by the yin cooling of tofu, purple cabbage, and black beans. Green vegetables sit at the center, stabilizing the entire meal.

## More Example Meals to Try

### Example 3: Mediterranean Lunch Bowl

|                                  |     |
|----------------------------------|-----|
| ● Mixed greens, cucumber (green) | 0   |
| ● Cherry tomatoes (red)          | +8  |
| ● Lemon dressing (yellow)        | +2  |
| ● Chickpeas (light yellow)       | +1  |
| ● Kalamata olives (dark purple)  | -9  |
| ● Feta cheese (white)            | -10 |
| ● Carrot ribbons (orange)        | +5  |

**Total: -3 -- Well balanced, slightly cooling.**

### Example 4: Stir-Fry Dinner

|                                         |     |
|-----------------------------------------|-----|
| ● Broccoli, snap peas (green)           | 0   |
| ● Red bell pepper (light red)           | +7  |
| ● Carrots (orange)                      | +5  |
| ● Fresh ginger (light yellow)           | +1  |
| ● Tofu (white/grey)                     | -10 |
| ● Black sesame seeds (dark moist black) | -11 |
| ● Blueberries for dessert (blue)        | -2  |

**Total: -10 -- Cooling. Add brown rice (+3) or miso soup (+10) to balance.**

### Example 5: Balanced Smoothie

|                              |     |
|------------------------------|-----|
| ● Spinach (green)            | 0   |
| ● Strawberries (red)         | +8  |
| ● Banana (yellow)            | +2  |
| ● Blueberries (blue)         | -2  |
| ● Coconut milk (moist white) | -11 |
| ● Flax seeds (light yellow)  | +1  |

**Total: -2 -- Beautifully balanced.**

Example 6: Taco Night (Balanced)

|                                     |     |
|-------------------------------------|-----|
| ● Lettuce, cilantro, lime (green)   | 0   |
| ● Salsa, tomato (red)               | +8  |
| ● Corn tortilla (yellow)            | +2  |
| ● Orange pepper (orange)            | +5  |
| ● Purple cabbage slaw (dark purple) | -9  |
| ● Sour cream (white)                | -10 |
| ● Black beans (dark moist black)    | -12 |

Total: -16 -- Quite cooling. Add hot sauce or grilled meat to warm it up.

## Building Color-Balanced Meals

Now that you understand the scoring system, let's build practical meals. The key insight from Dr. Yeh: **you don't need exotic ingredients**. Every grocery store carries foods from every color group. It's simply a matter of choosing with awareness.

### The Color Balance Plate

Think of your plate as divided into five zones. Each zone represents a color temperature:

|                                                         |                                                                    |                                                             |                                                                           |                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Warm</b><br>Red foods<br>Tomato, beet,<br>red pepper | <b>Active</b><br>Orange & Yellow<br>Carrot, squash,<br>corn, lemon | <b>Center</b><br>Green foods<br>The anchor<br>of every meal | <b>Cool</b><br>Blue & Purple<br>Blueberry, grape,<br>eggplant,<br>cabbage | <b>Deep</b><br>White & Black<br>Tofu, mushroom,<br>onion, sesame |
|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|

### Meal Templates

#### Morning Template

Start with a **green base** (spinach, kale). Add one **warm color** (berries, banana). Add one **cool color** (blueberry, coconut). Optional: a sprinkle of **dark** (black sesame, chia seeds).

*Try:* Green smoothie with spinach, strawberry, banana, blueberry, and coconut milk.

#### Lunch Template

Build a **salad or grain bowl** with: greens as the base, two warm-colored toppings (tomato, carrot, corn), one cool topping (purple cabbage, olive), and a white or black element (feta, beans, mushroom).

*Try:* Kale bowl with roasted sweet potato, cherry tomatoes, corn, purple cabbage, and a lemon-tahini dressing.

## Dinner Template

Cook a **protein** (score varies by color). Serve with **two green vegetables** (0 balance). Add a **starch from a complementary color** -- if protein is red (yang), pair with purple or black rice (yin). If protein is white (yin), pair with sweet potato or miso (yang).

*Try:* Grilled salmon (+7) with steamed broccoli (0), roasted purple potatoes (-7), and a side of black rice (-12) with lemon (+2). Total: -10. Add a drizzle of chili oil for warmth.

## Snack Ideas by Color

### Red / Orange / Yellow (+)

Apple slices, dried apricots, carrot sticks, mango, cherry tomatoes, tangerines, golden raisins

### Green (0)

Cucumber slices, celery with hummus, edamame, green grapes, snap peas, avocado toast, green apple

### Blue / Purple (-)

Blueberries, blackberries, purple grapes, acai bowl, eggplant dip, dried figs, purple plums

### White / Black (-)

Coconut chips, white mushroom slices, jicama sticks, black bean dip, black sesame crackers, tofu bites

## Quick Tips for Every Color Group

- **Red:** Tomato sauce and salsa count! You don't need whole red foods at every meal.
- **Orange/Yellow:** Roasted butternut squash and sweet potato are versatile, affordable, and store well.
- **Green:** Keep frozen broccoli, spinach, and peas on hand. They retain their color value when frozen.
- **Blue/Purple:** Frozen blueberries are one of the most cost-effective ways to add blue. Purple cabbage lasts weeks in the fridge.
- **White/Black:** Tofu, mushrooms, onions, and garlic are pantry staples that add yin balance to any meal. Black beans and black rice are affordable and widely available.

# Quick Reference Charts

## Foods by Color Group

Use this chart at the grocery store. Every item listed is widely available at standard American supermarkets.

| Color (Value)       | Common Foods                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ● Charcoal (+12)    | Charcoal-grilled foods, very dark toast                                                                                                      |
| ● Dry Black (+10)   | Coffee, black pepper, dark roast tea, espresso, cocoa powder                                                                                 |
| ● Dark Red (+9)     | Red apple (peel), red onion, adzuki bean, cranberry, pomegranate, kidney bean                                                                |
| ● Red (+8)          | Tomato, red bell pepper, strawberry, red meat, red beet, cherry, red grape                                                                   |
| ● Light Red (+7)    | Watermelon, goji berry, raspberry, red radish, pink grapefruit, salmon                                                                       |
| ● Dark Orange (+6)  | Pumpkin, sweet potato, millet, papaya, turmeric, butternut squash                                                                            |
| ● Orange (+5)       | Carrot, tangerine, orange, apricot, peach, persimmon, nectarine                                                                              |
| ● Light Orange (+4) | Orange juice, cantaloupe, mango, mandarin segments                                                                                           |
| ● Dark Yellow (+3)  | Golden beet, saffron, yellow bell pepper (dark), turmeric tea                                                                                |
| ● Yellow (+2)       | Lemon, egg yolk, corn, butter, banana, yellow squash, pineapple ring                                                                         |
| ● Light Yellow (+1) | Napa cabbage, sesame seed, pineapple, chickpea, ginger, white corn                                                                           |
| ● Green (0)         | <b>Broccoli, spinach, kale, celery, cucumber, green beans, avocado, zucchini, peas, lettuce, green apple, herbs, green pepper, asparagus</b> |
| ● Light Blue (-1)   | Filtered water, spirulina (in smoothies)                                                                                                     |
| ● Blue (-2)         | Blueberry, blue corn tortilla chips                                                                                                          |



| Color (Value)             | Common Foods                                                                     |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ● Dark Blue (-3)          | Liver (beef or chicken), dark plum                                               |
| ● Light Purple (-7)       | Lavender, light purple potato, turnip (purple-tipped)                            |
| ● Purple (-8)             | Blackberry, eggplant, nori (seaweed), purple yam                                 |
| ● Dark Purple (-9)        | Purple grape, purple cabbage, purple fig, acai, Concord grape, black plum        |
| ● Light Grey/White (-10)  | Tofu, soy sauce, white mushroom, cauliflower, white onion, garlic, jicama        |
| ● Moist Black/White (-11) | Daikon, coconut, black sesame, milk (cow/goat/soy), egg white, wood ear mushroom |
| ● Dark Moist Black (-12)  | Black bean, black/wild rice, black mushroom (shiitake), dark seaweed             |

## Your Daily Color Scorecard

Print this page and use it to track your color balance for a day. Write in each food you eat, note its color value, and total each meal.

# Daily Color Scorecard

Date: \_\_\_\_\_

| Food Item   | Color | Value |
|-------------|-------|-------|
| Breakfast   |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
| Lunch       |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
| Dinner      |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
| Snacks      |       |       |
|             |       |       |
|             |       |       |
| Daily Total |       |       |

Target: between -5 and +5 | Perfect balance = 0

## If You're Craving a Color, Your Body May Need...

Dr. Yeh observed that food cravings often reflect genuine physiological needs. Pay attention to the colors you're drawn to:

● **Craving red?**

Your heart and circulatory system may need attention. Try red beans, beets, or red apples instead of red meat.

● **Craving orange/yellow?**

Your digestive system may be asking for support. Reach for pumpkin, squash, carrots, or corn.

● **Craving green?**

Your whole body wants to rebalance. Eat freely -- green is the one color you cannot overdo.

● **Craving blue/purple?**

Your kidneys and bones may need nourishment. Try blueberries, purple cabbage, grapes, or eggplant.

● **Craving white?**

Your lungs and immune system may need support. Try daikon, onion, cauliflower, or mushrooms.

● **Craving dark/black?**

Dry black (coffee, pepper) signals an energy deficit. Moist black (black beans, rice) signals deep nourishment needs.

## Putting It All Together

You now have every tool you need to start eating with color awareness. Here is how to begin -- simply and without overwhelm.

### Start Simple: The Five-Color Rule

Before you worry about scoring, just aim for this: **include at least five different colors at every meal.** If your plate has red, orange, green, purple, and white, you are almost certainly in a reasonable balance range. This single habit will transform the nutritional quality of your meals.

### The 3-Day Color Challenge

Try this introductory challenge to build your color awareness:

#### Your 3-Day Color Challenge

##### Day 1: Observe

Don't change anything. Just notice the colors on your plate at every meal. Write them down in the scorecard on the previous page. At the end of the day, tally your score.

Most people are surprised to discover their diet is heavily yang (warm) -- too much red meat, coffee, bread, and fried food.

##### Day 2: Add Green

Keep eating normally, but add one serving of green vegetables to every meal. A handful of spinach in your morning smoothie. A side salad at lunch. Steamed broccoli at dinner. Notice how this single addition changes your daily score.

##### Day 3: Balance the Spectrum

Now aim for five colors at every meal. Use the meal templates from Chapter 5 as inspiration. Score your plate and see how close you can get to zero. Most people find this surprisingly enjoyable -- colorful plates are simply more appealing to eat.

# How Color Balance Changes with the Seasons

Dr. Yeh taught that the ideal color balance shifts throughout the year. In winter, the body benefits from slightly more warming (yang) foods -- hearty soups, roasted root vegetables, warming spices. In summer, it thrives on cooling (yin) foods -- fresh salads, berries, cucumbers, and raw vegetables.

This seasonal dimension is a core teaching in Dr. Yeh's book *Seasonal Balanced Food Medicine*, and a topic we explore fully in the companion guide: ***The Seasonal Color Guide***.

## Quick Seasonal Guidelines

- **Spring:** Emphasize green and light foods. The body is ready to cleanse after winter.
- **Summer:** Favor yin foods (blues, purples, whites). Your body needs cooling.
- **Autumn:** Increase white foods (lung support) and begin adding warming orange and yellow.
- **Winter:** Lean into warming reds, oranges, and dry blacks. Add moist blacks for deep nourishment.

## A Final Word

Dr. Yeh dedicated his life to making the vast wisdom of Traditional Chinese Medicine accessible and practical. The Food Color Balance system is one of his most elegant contributions -- a bridge between ancient observation and modern daily life.

You don't need to be perfect. You don't need to score every meal to the decimal point. Simply bring awareness to the colors on your plate, strive for variety, and let your body do what it already knows how to do: heal, balance, and thrive.





## From the Yeh Center E-Book Collection



*The TCM Food Color Guide -- You are here*

*The Seasonal Color Guide -- Adjusting your plate for  
spring, summer, autumn, and winter*

*Seasonal Balanced Food Medicine -- Dr. Yeh's complete  
teachings on food as medicine*

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